is discussed in everyday life. This research formed a part of the Myanmar Media and Society (M.MAS) project, a partnership between St Antony's College, Oxford University and the Myanmar ICT for Development Organization (MIDO).[1]

One of the things I raised in my conference presentation was the similarity between discourses about Islam that I was hearing in Myanmar and those I had heard in my home country, the United States. We should note parallels between these discourses, I said, and consider what it may mean that the arguments called upon to justify anti-Muslim sentiments in Myanmar are strikingly similar to those I remember in the US after 9/11. You may notice similarities to discourses in the US or Australia today, I also suggested. The first member of the audience to ask a question refused this parallel. "Why are we spending so much time listening to bigots?" she asked. "Would we give such careful attention to the beliefs of Holocaust deniers?" The question presented a different analogy, in which those expressing anti-Muslim sentiments in Myanmar are equivalent to deniers of the Holocaust. This was its refusal: the question positioned discourses in Myanmar as far from home as possible, more analogous to Holocaust deniers — a fringe group most reviled — than anything commonplace on the streets of Sydney, New York, or London.

I would like to take this question seriously by asking: what are the consequences of such a refusal? Conversely, why might it be important to explore relationships between anti-Muslim discourses currently circulating in Myanmar and those elsewhere? This chapter argues that answering these questions is necessary if we are to make any sense of contemporary communal violence in Myanmar.[2] Noting parallels between anti-Muslim discourses in Myanmar and the West necessitates asking: how shall we explain them? Shall we say they are just a coincidence, or that they reveal a universal truth about Islam? Apparently similar phenomena can arise for different reasons, of course, but both answers seem unsatisfactory; too flippant, too essentialising. Neither would it be satisfactory to say that anti-Muslim discourses in Myanmar are *produced* by those in the West — this would mirror old-fashioned diffusionist anthropology or early historiographies of Southeast Asia, which saw developments within the region as derivative, triggered primarily by external intervention. To say instead that anti-Muslim violence in Myanmar is endogenous would be to locate agency primarily within people in Myanmar. This is an important project, yet such an approach also risks ignoring the parallels I have